by successive armies of Assyrians, Babylonians, Persians, Greeks, Romans, and Arabs.

During the late nineteenth century, seeking refuge from the anti-Semitism common in much of Europe, some Jews—known as Zionists—began asserting the right to reclaim this ancient territory as a national homeland for Jews. In 1948, as the world mourned the monstrous crimes of the Holocaust, the Zionists achieved their goal and the State of Israel was born. But with the creation of the new homeland for Jews, the Arabs who had been occupying Palestine for centuries became a stateless people—and a volatile and frustrated force eager to reclaim land they considered *their* homeland.

The Arab world declared war on Israel, and three times, in 1948, 1967, and 1973, the tiny new country courageously drove back its enemies. Throughout its brief history, Israel has had to live in a perpetual state of war as the constant target of Palestinian terror, a small country fighting for the acceptance of neighbors sworn to destroy it.

This conflict alone would make the Middle East a tinderbox. But animosity, prejudice, and divisions among the Arabs have made it even more volatile. First, there are nationalistic and political rivalries among Arab tribes that go back centuries and make them a far from cohesive or politically united people. Then there are deep and bitter divisions among the Palestinians. Although the Palestine Liberation Organization, which wants an independent Palestinian state, claims to speak for all Palestinians, it is splintered into rival factions ranging from relatively moderate ones to those led by bloodthirsty fanatics. Moreover, the creation of an independent Palestinian state dominated by the PLO is the last thing the leaders of some Arab countries want, even though they may publicly endorse the idea.